# Troop 500G Handbook

Scouting America Troop 500G, Solon, Ohio

Lake Erie Council

October 2026

## Contents


**1 About Troop 500G** **2**
- 1.1 Our Mission . . . 2
- 1.2 Accessibility and Inclusion . . . 2
- 1.3 Meeting Information . . . 2
- 1.4 Scouting America's Foundation . . . 2
- 1.5 Our Charter Organization . . . 3
- 1.6 Lake Erie Council . . . 4

**2 Troop Organization** **4**
- 2.1 The Patrol Method . . . 5
- 2.2 Youth Leadership Positions . . . 5
- 2.3 Adult Leadership . . . 7
- 2.4 Troop 500G Committee . . . 8

**3 Parents Guide** **10**
- 3.1 The First Meeting . . . 10
- 3.2 The First Campout . . . 12
- 3.3 The First Semi-Annual Planning Conference . . . 14
- 3.4 The First Summer Camp . . . 15
- 3.5 Youth Leadership: What Parents Need to Know . . . 15
- 3.6 Getting Involved . . . 17

**4 Advancement Guide** **18**
- 4.1 Advancement to Scout . . . 18
- 4.2 Advancement to First Class . . . 20
- 4.3 The Path to Eagle . . . 23

**5 Adult Leaders Guide** **26**
- 5.1 Expectations of Adult Leaders . . . 26
- 5.2 Becoming an Adult Leader . . . 27
- 5.3 Youth Protection Trained Adult (Not an Adult Leader) . . . 28
- 5.4 Scouter Reserve . . . 29
- 5.5 Merit Badge Counselor . . . 29
- 5.6 Committee Member . . . 29
- 5.7 Assistant Scoutmaster . . . 30
- 5.8 Scoutmaster . . . 30
- 5.9 Charter Organization Representative . . . 30
- 5.10 Additional Training Opportunities . . . 31

**6 Outdoor Program & High Adventure** **32**
6.1 Building the Foundation: Monthly Outdoor Program . . . . . 32
6.2 The Path to High Adventure . . . . . 33
6.3 Leave No Trace . . . . . 34
6.4 Summer Camp . . . . . 34
6.5 Getting Involved . . . . . 35

**7 Appendix** **35**
7.1 Appendix A: Joining Conference . . . . . 35
7.2 Appendix B: Scout Camps We Frequent . . . . . 45
7.3 Appendix C: Useful Links . . . . . 47
7.4 Appendix D: Troop Contact Information . . . . . 48

---

Welcome to the official handbook for Scouting America Troop 500G. This handbook serves as your comprehensive guide to troop operations, policies, procedures, and resources.

---

*Last Updated: {{ site.time | date: "%B %Y" }}*
*For questions about this handbook, contact the Scoutmaster or visit us at our weekly meetings.*

# 1 About Troop 500G

Troop 500G is a female Scouting America troop based in Solon, Ohio. We are a proud part of the Lake Erie Council and are chartered by Advent Lutheran Church.

## 1.1 Our Mission

To provide girls with opportunities to develop leadership skills, experience outdoor adventures, serve their community, and advance toward Eagle Scout while building lifelong friendships.

## 1.2 Accessibility and Inclusion

Troop 500G welcomes all female youth who want to participate in Scouting, regardless of ability, background, or circumstance. We adapt activities and provide reasonable accommodations so every Scout can participate meaningfully. If your Scout has specific needs, please reach out to the Scoutmaster or Committee Chair so we can work together on a plan.

For more information, see the Scouting America Accessibility and Inclusion Information Booklet.

## 1.3 Meeting Information

- **Regular Meetings**: Monday evenings, 7:00-8:30 PM at Advent Lutheran Church, Solon, OH
- **Summer Schedule**: Monday evenings, 6:30-8:00 PM at South Chagrin Reservation Shelterhouse
  *Check the events calendar for current meeting times and locations.*

## 1.4 Scouting America's Foundation

Understanding Scouting America's mission and methods helps families appreciate the comprehensive youth development program your Scout will experience.

**1.4.0.1 Mission Statement** The mission of Scouting America is to prepare young people to make ethical and moral choices over their lifetimes by instilling in them the values of the Scout Oath and Law.

**1.4.0.2 Vision Statement** Scouting America will prepare every eligible youth in America to become a responsible, participating citizen and leader who is guided by the Scout Oath and Law.

### 1.4.1 The Scout Oath

On my honor I will do my best To do my duty to God and my country and to obey the Scout Law; To help other people at all times; To keep myself physically strong, mentally awake, and morally straight.

### 1.4.2 The Scout Law

A Scout Is: Trustworthy, Loyal, Helpful, Friendly, Courteous, Kind, Obedient, Cheerful, Thrifty, Brave, Clean, Reverent

### 1.4.3 Scouting's Aims and Methods

Scouting achieves its mission through four main aims: **character development**, **leadership development**, **citizenship training**, and **personal fitness**. These are accomplished through eight interconnected methods:

1. **Ideals** - Living by the Scout Oath, Law, motto, and slogan
2. **Patrols** - Small group experiences that teach responsibility and citizenship
3. **Outdoor Programs** - Learning through nature and outdoor adventures
4. **Advancement** - Progressive challenges that build self-confidence and skills
5. **Association with Adults** - Positive role modeling and mentoring relationships
6. **Personal Growth** - Individual development through service and reflection
7. **Leadership Development** - Learning and practicing leadership skills
8. **Uniform** - Visible commitment to Scouting ideals and community service

More information: Scouting's Aims and Methods

## 1.5 Our Charter Organization

A chartered organization is a community group — such as a church, civic organization, or school — that partners with Scouting America to sponsor and support a local unit, providing a meeting place and organizational oversight.

**Advent Lutheran Church**
5525 Harper Road
Solon, OH 44139
Phone: (440) 248-6904
Website: adventsolon.org

**Location Map:** Visit Google Maps: Advent Lutheran Church, 5525 Harper Road, Solon, OH

We are grateful for the support and partnership of Advent Lutheran Church, which provides us with meeting space and organizational support.

### 1.6 Lake Erie Council




\

**Lake Erie Council, BSA**
Troop 500G is proudly part of the Lake Erie Council, which serves Scouts across Northeast Ohio. The Lake Erie Council provides training, resources, and support to help units deliver high-quality Scouting programs that build character, citizenship, and fitness in young people.

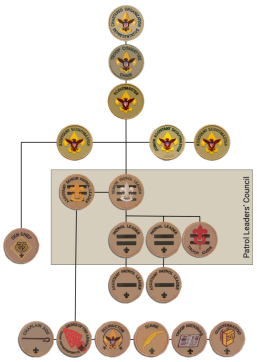
The Lake Erie Council was formed on January 1, 2017, through the consolidation of parts of the Greater Cleveland Council, Greater Western Reserve Council, and Heart of Ohio Council, creating a unified organization that now serves the areas previously covered by these entities.

**Contact Information:**
2241 Woodland Ave.
Cleveland, OH 44115
Phone: (216) 861-6060
Email: LECMemberCare@scouting.org
Website: lecscouting.org

**Mailing Address:**
PO Box 93388
Cleveland, OH 44101-5388

## 2 Troop Organization

Troop 500G operates under the Scouting America troop leadership model, where youth leaders are elected by the troop and adult leaders provide guidance and support to all youth-led activities.




*Sample Troop Organization Structure*

The chart above illustrates a typical Scouting America troop structure, which Troop 500G adheres to. Youth leaders are elected by their peers and supported by adult volunteers, ensuring a Scout-led program at every

level.

## 2.1 The Patrol Method

A Scout patrol is a small team of normally six to eight members where Scouts learn skills together, share responsibilities, and take on leadership roles. Each patrol elects its own patrol leader and develops its own identity and traditions.

"The patrol system is not one method in which Scouting can be carried on. It is the only method." —Lord Baden-Powell, Scouting's founder

For more information about the patrol method, see the Scouting America Patrol Method Guide.

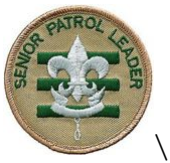
### 2.1.1 New Scout Patrol

Troop 500G uses a New Scout Patrol for all new Scouts joining the troop who have not yet earned the Scout rank, including incoming Arrow of Light crossover Scouts. This patrol has its own identity and is led by a Troop Guide — an experienced Scout appointed to mentor new members as they transition into the troop. The Troop Guide helps new Scouts learn the basics of troop life, build confidence, and work toward early rank advancement.

While the New Scout Patrol meets and operates as its own patrol during regular troop meetings, new Scouts roll into one of our regular patrols for campouts based on individual campout participation. This approach gives new Scouts a supportive learning environment while also integrating them into the broader troop experience in the field.

For more information about the New Scout Patrol and the Troop Guide role, see the Scouting America Troop Guide and the New-Scout Patrol Guide.

## 2.2 Youth Leadership Positions




### 2.2.1 Senior Patrol Leader (SPL)

\

The senior patrol leader is the highest youth leadership position in the troop, elected by the Scouts. They serve as the primary link between the troop's Scouts and its adult leaders. The SPL leads troop meetings, runs the patrol leaders' council, and drives planning for outdoor activities, service projects, and events.

**Senior Patrol Leader Responsibilities:** - Runs all troop meetings, events, activities, and the annual program planning conference - Runs the patrol leaders' council (PLC) meetings - Appoints other troop youth leaders with the advice and counsel of the Scoutmaster - Assigns duties and responsibilities to youth leaders - Assists the Scoutmaster with youth leader training - Sets a good example - Wears the Scout uniform correctly - Lives by the Scout Oath and Law - Shows Scout spirit

For more information about the Senior Patrol Leader role, see the Scouting America Senior Patrol Leader Guide and refer to Scouting America Publication *Senior Patrol Leader Handbook*.




### 2.2.2 Patrol Leaders

Each patrol elects its own patrol leader. The patrol leader is the patrol's key leader, representing the patrol at patrol leaders' council meetings and the annual program planning conference. They plan and lead patrol meetings and activities, keep members informed, and ensure the patrol is prepared for all troop activities. Patrol leaders set the example for their patrol and the rest of the troop.

**Patrol Leader Responsibilities:** - Plans and leads patrol meetings and activities - Keeps patrol members informed - Assigns each patrol member a specific duty - Represents the patrol at all patrol leaders' council meetings and the annual program planning conference - Prepares the patrol to participate in all troop activities - Works with other troop leaders to make the troop run well - Knows the abilities of each patrol member - Sets a good example - Wears the Scout uniform correctly - Lives by the Scout Oath and Law - Shows and develops patrol spirit

For more information about the Patrol Leader role, see the Scouting America Patrol Leader Guide and refer to Scouting America Publication *The Patrol Leader Handbook*.




### 2.2.3 Quartermaster

The Quartermaster serves as the troop's supply boss. They maintain an inventory of troop equipment and ensure gear is in good condition. They coordinate with patrol quartermasters to check out and return equipment, and report on replacement or repair needs at patrol leaders' council meetings.

**Quartermaster Responsibilities:** - Keeps records on patrol and troop equipment - Makes sure equipment is in good working condition - Issues equipment and makes sure it is returned in good condition - Makes suggestions for new or replacement items - Works with the troop committee member responsible for equipment - Sets a good example - Wears the Scout uniform correctly - Lives by the Scout Oath and Law - Shows Scout spirit

For more information about the Quartermaster role, see the Scouting America Quartermaster Guide.




### 2.2.4 Scribe

The scribe is the troop's secretary. They attend patrol leaders' council meetings and keep a record of the discussions. They work with patrol scribes to track attendance and maintain troop advancement records.

**Scribe Responsibilities:** - Attends and keeps a log of patrol leaders' council meetings - Records individual Scout attendance - Records individual Scout advancement progress - Works with the troop committee member responsible for records and finance - Sets a good example - Wears the Scout uniform correctly - Lives by the Scout Oath and Law - Shows Scout spirit

For more information about the Scribe role, see the Scouting America Scribe Guide.

**Other Troop Positions**: Additional leadership positions available

## 2.3 Adult Leadership




### 2.3.1 Scoutmaster

\

The Scoutmaster is the adult responsible for working directly with the Scouts, providing direction, coaching, and support.

**The Scoutmaster has three basic roles:** - Providing the youth leaders with the tools and skills so they can run the troop - Making sure the rules of Scouting America and the chartered partner are followed - Being a good mentor and positive role model

For more information about the Scoutmaster role, see the Scouting America Scoutmaster Guide.

**More Resources:** - Every youth deserves a trained leader. See more about training opportunities for adults including Scoutmasters - BSA Publication *Troop Leader Guidebook*




### 2.3.2 Assistant Scoutmaster

\

The assistant Scoutmasters are adult leaders over the age of 18 who help the Scoutmaster deliver the promise of Scouting. Each assistant Scoutmaster is assigned specific program duties. They can serve the troop by guiding a particular patrol, advising Scouts in appointed positions (e.g., the quartermaster or OA representative), or filling in as needed to ensure youth leaders have what they need to run things.

They also provide the two-deep leadership required by Scouting America. An assistant Scoutmaster may be 18 years old, but at least one in each troop should be 21 or older so they can serve in the Scoutmaster's absence.

For more information about the Assistant Scoutmaster role, see the Scouting America Assistant Scoutmaster Guide.




### 2.3.3 Chartered Organization Representative

\

Available position. The Chartered Organization Representative (COR) is the direct contact between the unit and the Chartered Organization. This individual is also the organization's contact with the District Committee and the Local Council. The chartered organization representative may become a member of the district committee and is a voting member of the council. If the chartered organization has more than

one unit, one representative serves them all. The Chartered Organization Representative appoints the Unit Committee Chairman.

For more information about the Chartered Organization Representative role, see the Scouting America Chartered Organization Representative Guide and the Chartered Organization Representative Position Description.

For detailed information about all adult leadership positions and responsibilities, see the Scouting America Troop Structure Guide.

## 2.4 Troop 500G Committee

The troop committee is a cross between a board of directors and a parent support group. It sets troop policies and handles administrative functions, allowing the Scoutmaster and assistant Scoutmasters to focus on working directly with the Scouts.

A robust troop committee supports an effective Scouting program. Below is a list of common and desirable roles for adults within the troop committee.




### 2.4.1 Committee Chair

\

**Available position**
The troop committee chair is appointed by the chartered organization to see that all committee functions are carried out. The troop committee chair appoints and supervises the unit committee and unit leaders, and organizes the committee to see that all committee responsibilities are delegated, coordinated, and completed.

**Committee Chair Duties:** - Organize the committee to see that all functions are delegated, coordinated, and completed - Maintain a close relationship with the chartered organization representative and the Scoutmaster - Interpret national and local policies to the troop - Prepare troop committee meeting agendas - Call, preside over, and promote attendance at monthly troop committee meetings and any special meetings that may be called - Ensure troop representation at roundtables - Secure top-notch, trained individuals for camp leadership - Arrange for charter review and recharter annually - Plan the charter presentation

For more information about the Committee Chair role, see the Scouting America Committee Chairman Guide.

### 2.4.2 Secretary

**Duties:** - Keep minutes of meetings and send out committee meeting notices - Handle publicity - Prepare a family newsletter of troop events and activities - Conduct troop resource survey - Plan for family night programs and family activities - At each meeting, report the minutes of the previous meeting

### 2.4.3 Treasurer

**Duties:** - Handle all troop funds. Pay bills on recommendation of the Scoutmaster and authorization of the troop committee - Maintain checking and/or savings accounts - Train and supervise the troop scribe in record keeping - Keep adequate records - Supervise money-earning projects, including obtaining proper

authorizations - Supervise the camp savings plan - Lead in the preparation of the annual troop budget - Lead the Friends of Scouting campaign - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

#### 2.4.4 Outdoor Activities Coordinator

**Duties:** - Help in securing permission to use camping sites - Serve as transportation coordinator - Ensure a monthly outdoor program - Promote the National Camping Award - Promote, through family meetings, attendance at troop campouts, camporees, and summer camp to reach the goal of an outing per month - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

#### 2.4.5 Advancement Coordinator

**Duties:** - Encourage Scouts to advance in rank - Work with the troop scribe to maintain all Scout advancement records - Arrange quarterly troop boards of review and courts of honor - Recruit merit badge counselors - Make a prompt report of advancements using online tools or appropriate paper forms to the council service center. Secure badges and certificates - Work with the troop librarian to build and maintain a troop library of merit badge pamphlets and other advancement literature - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

#### 2.4.6 Chaplain

**Duties:** - Provide a spiritual tone for troop meetings and activities - Give guidance to the chaplain aide - Promote regular participation of each member in the activities of the religious organization of their choice - Encourage Scouts to earn their appropriate religious emblems - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

#### 2.4.7 Training Coordinator

**Duties:** - Ensure troop leaders and committee members have opportunities for training - Maintain an inventory of up-to-date training materials and resources - Be responsible for Youth Protection Training compliance within the troop - Encourage periodic youth leadership training within the troop and at the council and national levels - Report to the troop committee at each meeting - Assist in orientation to new parents - Be watchful that the troop is taking all steps to ensure youth safety

#### 2.4.8 Equipment Coordinator

**Duties:** - Supervise and help the troop procure camping equipment - Work with the quartermaster on inventory and proper storage and maintenance of all troop equipment - Make periodic safety checks on all troop camping gear, and encourage the troop in the safe use of all outdoor equipment - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

#### 2.4.9 Membership Coordinator

**Duties:** - Develop a plan for year-round membership flow into the troop - Work closely with the Cubmaster and Webelos/AOL den leaders of neighboring Cub Scout packs to provide a smooth transition from pack to troop. Assist in developing and recruiting den chiefs, and assist in the crossover ceremony - Plan and coordinate troop open houses to invite non-Scouts into the troop - Encourage Scouts to invite their friends to the troop - Keep track of Scouts who drop out of the troop, and develop a plan to encourage them to rejoin - Report to the troop committee at each meeting

This is not an exhaustive list of positions a troop may need. Troops are encouraged to engage all parents in a role that suits their skills and interests.

The essential support literature for troop committee members is the Scouting America publication *Scouts BSA Troop Committee Guidebook*.

# 3 Parents Guide

Welcome to Scouting America Troop 500G! We are happy to have you and your daughter join us for the awesome adventure of Scouting!

Scouting is a new experience for both Scout and parent. There is a time when the parents, although still involved in new ways, take a step back and let their daughters take on more and more responsibility for their achievements. While Scouting is girl-led, it is parent-facilitated. Your role as a facilitator requires a commitment of your time on both organizational and activity levels. This guide provides what a parent needs to know to survive the first year of Scout life.

All troop members are expected to follow the Scout Oath and Law in their behavior during troop activities and in their daily lives.

---

## 3.1 The First Meeting

We meet Monday evenings at Advent Lutheran Church (regular meetings 7:00-8:30 PM, summer meetings 6:30-8:00 PM). All activities are tracked in Scoutbook and Google Calendar, and we organize monthly outings for advancement and merit badges.

You may not have everything we list as required when you start - don't worry! Do your best, show up ready to learn about Scouting, and we'll work with you on the rest. More detailed information about meetings and activities can be found later in the handbook.

### 3.1.1 Troop Communications

We use GroupMe for routine chats following all Youth Protection Training two-deep policies. We have groups for the troop, committee, parents, and each patrol, as well as groups for specific events as needed. We use Scoutbook as much as possible to keep all information in one place. Adult leaders also use a Google Drive, but we are working to move as much information as possible onto the website troop500.org to reduce the number of locations we need to access.

### 3.1.2 Documents, Sites and Training

Getting started with Troop 500 involves a few important steps to keep everyone safe and connected. You'll need to complete some paperwork, get familiar with our digital tools, and take care of some training requirements. Don't worry - we'll walk you through everything! Here's what you and your Scout need to take care of within your first month, and definitely before your Scout's first campout.

**Register with Scouting America** If you haven't already registered with Scouting America, visit BeAScout.scouting.org which will walk you through the registration process as well as provide resources for finding other Scouting units around us.

**My.Scouting.org** My.Scouting.org is where you'll create your Scouting America account, complete training requirements like Safeguarding Youth, and manage your annual membership renewal. This is your central hub for all official Scouting America business and training.

**Scoutbook** Every Scout, adult leader, and parent/guardian should have a Scoutbook account. Scoutbook uses your My.Scouting.org account and is the official digital platform for Scouting America that tracks advancement, activities, and communication. Your Scout's progress, merit badge requirements, and troop calendar are all managed through Scoutbook. Parents and Scouts can access Scoutbook through the web at scoutbook.scouting.org or via the mobile app.

For help getting started with Scoutbook, download the Parents Trail Guide to Scoutbook.

**Guide to Safe Scouting** All participants in official Scouting activities should become familiar with the Guide to Safe Scouting and applicable program literature or manuals, and be aware of state or local government regulations that supersede Scouting America practices, policies, and guidelines. The Guide to Safe Scouting is an overview of Scouting policies and procedures gleaned from a variety of sources.

Guide to Safe Scouting: https://www.scouting.org/health-and-safety/gss/

**Social Media Waiver** Troop 500G occasionally takes photos and videos during meetings, events, and outings for promotional purposes, social media posts, and documentation of activities. The Social Media Waiver allows families to specify their preferences regarding photography and the use of their Scout's image in troop communications and social media. This form ensures we respect each family's privacy wishes while still being able to share the great experiences and achievements of our troop.

Download: Troop 500 Social Media Waiver

**Safeguarding Youth** Safeguarding Youth training is required for all Scouting America registered volunteers and is a joining requirement that must be renewed annually. If training is not current at registration renewal, the volunteer will not be re-registered. This training is strongly encouraged for parents and guardians, and is required for any adult attending longer campouts (72+ hours) like summer resident camp.

More information: https://www.scouting.org/training/youth-protection/

### 3.1.3 Gear Up

As an organization focused on a wide variety of activities, it is easy to either overspend on gear or become overwhelmed by everything you think you need. A Scout is thrifty - please do not buy everything you think you'll need for your entire Scouting experience before your first meeting. The gear listed below consists of the basics that you need to get started. The troop also has access to some secondhand uniform items and can provide recommendations on the best way to gear up.

**Scout Handbook** Required for all advancement (*provided for new Scouts joining our troop*)

**Class A Uniform (Field Uniform)** The Class A uniform is purchased individually at the Scout Shop with some components provided by the troop.

**Class B Uniform (Activity Uniform)** The Class B uniform is purchased from the troop during your first couple of meetings.

**Scout 10 Essentials**

Learn more about the 10 Essentials

"Prepared. For Life." It's more than a motto for Scouting; it's a way to plan and execute each outing, even if it's just a Saturday morning hike. In the woods, the items here (stowed in a daypack) can keep you comfortable, warm, hydrated, safe and, most of all, prepared to face what nature puts in your path — whether you asked for it or not.

1. Pocket Knife
2. First Aid Kit
3. Extra Clothing
4. Rain Gear
5. Water Storage
6. Flashlight / Headlamp
7. Trail Food
8. Matches / Fire Starters
9. Sun Protection
10. Map / Compass

#### 3.1.4 Troop Fees and Expenses

**Annual Scouting America Membership Fees** All Scouts and adult leaders must complete annual membership renewal through My.Scouting.org.

**Annual Troop Dues** All Scouts owe annual dues as assessed by the Treasurer and Troop Committee. Checks are the preferred payment method — make checks payable to **Troop 500**.

**Event Fees** Event fees are collected by the troop Treasurer. Fees are paid in advance and are based on confirmed attendance.

For full details on payment methods, Scout Dollars, the sign-up and cancellation policy, financial assistance, and reimbursements, see the Financial Information page.

---

### 3.2 The First Campout

Your Scout's first overnight outing is a big milestone! There are a few things to take care of before they go.

#### 3.2.1 Sign Up in Scoutbook

All outings are managed through Scoutbook. Scoutmasters will post each event with a sign-up due date. **RSVP through Scoutbook on or before that date** — scouts who have not signed up by the deadline will not be able to attend. A Google Form may also be required; the link will be provided in the Scoutbook event.

Once you have signed up, you are financially committed to the event. If your Scout cannot attend after signing up, you are responsible for paying the fee or finding a replacement. See the Financial Information page for the full cancellation policy.

#### 3.2.2 Joining Conference

Every new Scout family is required to participate in a joining conference with troop leadership before their Scout's first overnight camping experience. This friendly, informative meeting helps us understand your

Scout's unique strengths, interests, and any special considerations that will help ensure their success in our program.

The joining conference is scheduled within the first month after joining and serves as an important step in creating a supportive environment where every Scout can thrive. During the conference, we'll discuss how we can work together as partners to provide the best possible Scouting experience and establish open communication.

For full details on what to expect and how to prepare, see the Joining Conference Template in the Appendix.

#### 3.2.3 Annual Health and Medical Record

For any and all Scouting activities, all participants must complete Part A and Part B of the Annual Health and Medical Record. "All participants" includes parents, guardians, siblings, youth, staff, and unit leaders. Part C (pre-participation physical by a licensed health-care provider) is required for events lasting longer than 72 hours, such as summer camp or high adventure activities, though all participants are encouraged to complete this during an annual exam.

Forms are available at: Scouting America Annual Health and Medical Record

#### 3.2.4 Camping Gear

The troop provides tents and cooking equipment, so you don't need to invest in those right away. Work with your patrol leader or Scoutmaster to get a packing list for the specific outing. As a starting point, every Scout should have their 10 Essentials and weather-appropriate clothing.

For a detailed packing reference, see the Packing and Gear section of the handbook.

#### 3.2.5 Support Your Scout

The best way to get involved is by helping your Scout do their best in the Scouting program. Remember, help and support does not mean do it for them. A key tenet of Scouting is to develop independent and capable leaders. As Lord Baden-Powell said, "Never do for a Scout what they can do for themselves."

Every Scout develops on their own timeline, and the level of support needed varies from Scout to Scout and changes over time. Some Scouts may need more guidance with organization and reminders, while others quickly become self-directed. What works for one Scout may not work for another, and that's completely normal! Talk to Scout leaders and other parents to learn more about everyone's Scouting journey - their experiences can provide valuable insights into supporting your own Scout's growth and development.

Here are ways to support your Scout's success: - Remind them to follow communications and schedules by reviewing Scoutbook and troop announcements together - Assist with getting their uniform together and ensuring they have required gear - Encourage them to take ownership of their advancement and merit badge progress - Support their leadership development by letting them solve problems and make decisions - Communicate with adult leaders about accessibility options or special considerations that help our leaders better understand how to work with and support your Scout along their Scouting journey - Be available for transportation when they need to attend meetings and activities - Help with setup and cleanup at events while letting your Scout take the lead on their responsibilities

**Advocate for Your Scout's Needs** Our troop provides an accessible and inclusive environment for every eligible youth. We will always do our best to support your Scout's needs, but you can help our best be

better. We require a joining meeting prior to your Scout's first overnight outing, but that's not the end of our discussion. You are encouraged to request a pre-event check-in with leaders attending any event (particularly helpful for summer camp) to ensure we can provide the best possible support for your Scout's success.

#### 3.2.6 Support Conferences

A Support Conference is an as-needed meeting between parents and leadership to address specific situations, plan for special events, or reassess a Scout's needs. Any leader, Scout, or parent may request a support conference at any time. These are especially helpful:

- **Before major events** — summer camp, high adventure, or activities that may present unique challenges
- **When needs change** — new medical considerations, behavioral concerns, or significant life changes
- **To celebrate progress** — discuss next steps, leadership opportunities, or strategies for challenging advancement requirements

To request a support conference, contact the Scoutmaster or any Assistant Scoutmaster. As with joining conferences, all information shared is kept confidential within our leadership team.

---

### 3.3 The First Semi-Annual Planning Conference

Twice a year, the Patrol Leaders' Council (PLC) holds a planning conference to build the troop's calendar for the next six months. This is one of the most important events in the troop — and your Scout has a voice in it from day one.

#### 3.3.1 How Your Scout Can Participate

Every Scout can contribute to the planning conference, even brand-new members. Before the conference, sit down with your Scout and:

- **Print out your school calendar and family calendar** — bring copies to share with the PLC so the troop can plan around school breaks, exam weeks, sports seasons, and family commitments
- **Start thinking about what the troop should do** — camping trips, skill-building activities, service projects, merit badge workshops, or just something fun. Your Scout's ideas matter, and the PLC wants to hear from everyone in the troop
- **Talk to their Patrol Leader** — Patrol Leaders represent their patrol at the PLC, so your Scout should share their ideas and schedule conflicts with their Patrol Leader before the conference

#### 3.3.2 What Happens at the Conference

Youth leaders — guided by adult mentors — work together to map out the next six months of troop activities, including:

- Monthly camping trips and outings
- Merit badge opportunities and advancement activities
- Service projects and community involvement
- Special events and courts of honor

- Summer camp or high adventure planning (when applicable)

#### 3.3.3 Why This Matters: Long-Term Planning

The semi-annual planning conference is how our troop stays organized and Scout-led. By planning six months at a time, Scouts learn to think ahead, coordinate with others, and balance commitments — skills that carry well beyond Scouting. It also means families get early visibility into the troop calendar, making it easier to plan around work schedules, vacations, and other activities.

When your Scout participates in this process — even just by sharing their family's calendar and a few ideas — they're contributing to a real team effort that shapes the troop's direction. That's leadership in action.

---

### 3.4 The First Summer Camp

Summer camp is a week-long adventure that accelerates your Scout's advancement and skill development. It's often the highlight of the Scouting year — and a bigger commitment for families than a weekend campout.

#### 3.4.1 Medical Form Part C

Part C of the Annual Health and Medical Record — a pre-participation physical by a licensed health-care provider — is **required** for all events lasting longer than 72 hours, including summer resident camp. Get this completed during your Scout's annual exam well in advance of camp registration.

Forms are available at: Scouting America Annual Health and Medical Record

#### 3.4.2 Safeguarding Youth for Attending Parents

Any parent or guardian who wishes to attend summer camp (or any event lasting 72+ hours) must have current Safeguarding Youth training on file. Complete it at my.scouting.org before the event.

#### 3.4.3 Pre-Event Check-In with Leaders

You are encouraged to request a pre-event check-in with the leaders attending any event — especially summer camp — to ensure we can provide the best possible support for your Scout. This is especially helpful if your Scout has specific needs, medical considerations, or has never been away from home for an extended time.

---

### 3.5 Youth Leadership: What Parents Need to Know

One of the most distinctive things about Scouting is that it is **youth-led**. Troop 500G operates using the patrol method, where Scouts — not adults — plan meetings, lead activities, and make decisions. This can be an adjustment for parents, especially when your Scout is elected or appointed to a leadership position for the first time.

#### 3.5.1 How Youth Leadership Works

Every six months, Scouts elect their troop and patrol leaders. These positions carry real responsibility:

- **Senior Patrol Leader (SPL)** — Leads troop meetings, chairs Patrol Leader Council, and coordinates with adult leaders
- **Assistant Senior Patrol Leader (ASPL)** — Supports and steps in for the SPL
- **Patrol Leaders** — Lead their patrol's meetings, activities, cooking, and camping
- **Quartermaster** — Manages troop or patrol equipment and inventory
- **Scribe** — Keeps attendance and meeting records

These aren't ceremonial titles. The Scouts who hold them are expected to plan, organize, lead, and follow through — and they will occasionally stumble. That's by design.

### 3.5.2 Supporting Without Doing

When your Scout takes on a leadership role, your instinct may be to help them succeed by organizing their notes, reminding them of every responsibility, or stepping in when things get messy. We get it — but the goal of youth leadership is for Scouts to develop these skills themselves, even when the process is imperfect.

Here's how you can support your young leader:

- **Ask questions instead of giving answers.** "What's your plan for the patrol meeting?" is more helpful than a to-do list.
- **Let them own the outcome.** A meeting that doesn't go perfectly is a learning experience, not a failure. Leaders grow by reflecting on what went well and what didn't.
- **Encourage, don't manage.** Celebrate their effort and growth, not just results. A Scout who led a campfire program that fell flat but tried their best learned more than one who had a parent orchestrate success behind the scenes.
- **Resist the rescue.** If your Scout forgets a responsibility, let them work through the consequences with their fellow Scouts and adult mentors. The troop's adult leaders are there to guide — and they'll intervene when it matters.
- **Be a sounding board.** Your Scout may come home frustrated about a decision that didn't go their way or a peer who isn't pulling their weight. Listen, empathize, and help them think through options rather than solving it for them.

### 3.5.3 What Adult Leaders Provide

Adult leaders serve as mentors and a safety net — not managers. The Scoutmaster and Assistant Scoutmasters coach youth leaders behind the scenes, ask guiding questions, and step in only when health, safety, or youth protection requires it. If you have concerns about how a leadership situation is going, talk to the Scoutmaster. They are watching, even when it looks like the Scouts are running the show on their own.

As your Scout takes on leadership responsibilities, you'll notice that adult leaders communicate more directly with them — not around them. Mentoring conversations, feedback on how a meeting went, and planning discussions happen between the adult leader and the Scout. Parents are always kept in the loop (you'll be copied on communications), but the dialogue is directed at your Scout because that's who is leading. All adult-youth communications follow Scouting America's two-deep leadership policy, so there is always more than one adult involved. This shift can feel unfamiliar at first, but it's an important part of treating your Scout as the leader they're becoming.

#### 3.5.4 Why It Matters

Holding a leadership position is a requirement for advancement to Star, Life, and Eagle ranks. More importantly, it builds the skills that Scouting is really about: responsibility, communication, problem-solving, and the confidence that comes from leading peers through real challenges. The less we do for our Scouts, the more capable they become.

For a full list of youth leadership positions, responsibilities, and the current roster, see the Youth Leadership Positions section of the handbook.

---

### 3.6 Getting Involved

Once your Scout has found their footing, there's a whole world of continued involvement for parents who want to give back. There's a lot to learn about Scouting in general and our troop specifically! Whether you're completely new to Scouting or earned your Eagle Scout rank back in the day, the program is always evolving. New families need time to understand how everything works, and even experienced Scouting parents find that each troop has its own culture and way of doing things. We encourage you to take time to observe and learn before jumping into formal roles.

#### 3.6.1 Attending Weekly Meetings

Parents are welcome to attend weekly meetings to learn about the troop! During meetings, Scouts and Scoutmasters will break away for dedicated skills instruction and Scout-led activities. While parents are ALWAYS welcome to observe, remember that Scouting is Scout-led and we encourage you to give your Scout room to learn and grow independently. Sometimes that means we'll let mistakes happen and allow interactions to play out naturally — our job is to create a safe and inclusive environment where Scouts can grow and learn from their experiences.

Please note that any direct contact volunteer leaders (those working directly with Scouts) are required to have completed Safeguarding Youth training before participating in Scouting activities.

**What Parents Can Do During Troop Meetings:** - Get to know the committee members and other parents, help us build our troop community - Learn about / sign up for upcoming events - Take on "service in a snap" tasks that help the troop function - Complete online training modules on your phone or device - Go on a grocery run! Life's busy and you don't have to attend every meeting unless you want to.

#### 3.6.2 Parent Meetings and Committee Meetings

- Attend monthly parent meetings to stay informed about troop activities and decisions
- Join committee meetings to participate in planning and troop business
- These meetings are great opportunities to ask questions and connect with other parents and leaders

#### 3.6.3 Support Your Troop

Even without a formal title, there are always ways to pitch in. Come to a committee meeting, show up to a parent meeting, or just ask any committee member how you can help — there's always more work than hands to do it.

- **Transportation**: Help with carpooling and equipment transport

- **Event Support**: Assist with setup, cleanup, and logistics at activities
- **Equipment Care**: Help maintain and organize troop gear

These activities typically require Safeguarding Youth Training and are a great way to see how the troop operates while making a real difference.

#### 3.6.4 Becoming an Adult Leader

Scouting is youth-led, but it doesn't happen without dedicated adults behind the scenes. We welcome and encourage all parents to consider taking on a leadership role — and there are options for every schedule and comfort level:

- **Scouter Reserve** is a registered adult leader without a dedicated weekly role. Scouter Reserves fill in where needed — serving as a second adult on campouts, driving to events, or stepping into a support role when the troop needs extra hands. It's a great option if your schedule doesn't allow a regular commitment but you still want to be trained, registered, and ready to help when you can.
- **Committee Members** handle the business side of Scouting — finances, planning, coordination — so Scoutmasters can focus on the youth program.
- **Merit Badge Counselors** share their professional or hobby expertise with Scouts on a flexible schedule.
- **Assistant Scoutmasters** work directly with patrols and youth leaders at meetings and outings.
- **Scoutmaster** is the primary youth program leader responsible for mentoring all youth leaders in the troop. The Scoutmaster is selected and confirmed by the chartered organization.

Every role matters, and every role requires training — starting with Safeguarding Youth and building from there. Not everyone has the capacity for a formal role right now, and that's completely fine. But if you're interested, we'd love to talk about where you might fit.

For full details on each role, training requirements, and how to get started, see the Adult Leaders Guide.

# 4 Advancement Guide

Scouting America advancement provides a progressive series of challenges that help Scouts develop skills, confidence, and leadership. Scouts can work on any requirement for advancement or merit badges at any time, but can only advance a rank when ALL requirements for that rank are completed. Rank advancement is earned — it is not automatic.

---

## 4.1 Advancement to Scout

Welcome to your Scouting adventure! Your Scout rank is your introduction to Scouting and the foundation for everything that follows. This rank should be completed within your first month and teaches you the fundamentals you need to participate fully in troop activities.

#### 4.1.1 Your First 30 Days: What to Expect

Starting Scouting is an exciting adventure! Here's what you can expect during your first month as you work toward earning your Scout rank.

#### 4.1.2 Your First Meeting Experience

When you walk into your first troop meeting, you'll be welcomed by your new Scout family:

**Meeting Your Patrol** - You'll be assigned to a patrol - your small group of fellow Scouts - Your patrol leader (an experienced Scout) will help guide you through your first meetings - Patrol members will become some of your closest friends in Scouting - You'll participate in patrol activities, games, and skill-building exercises

**Learning the Basics** - Practice the Scout Oath, Law, Motto, and Slogan - Learn the Scout sign, salute, and handshake - Understand how the patrol method works - Get familiar with your Scout handbook - Start working on basic knots and skills

#### 4.1.3 Scout Rank Requirements

Your Scout rank covers the essential knowledge every Scout needs. Here's what you'll learn and demonstrate:

**Scouting Knowledge** - **Scout Oath, Law, Motto, and Slogan**: Learn these by heart and explain what they mean to you - **Scout sign, salute, and handshake**: Understand when and how to use each one properly - **Patrol method**: Learn how Scouts work together in small groups - **Scout advancement**: Understand how you progress through ranks and earn merit badges - **Scout uniform**: Know how to wear your uniform properly with pride

**Basic Skills** - **Knots**: Show how to tie a square knot and two half-hitches - your first practical outdoor skills - **Pocketknife safety**: Demonstrate safe handling and the "blood circle" safety rule - **Citizenship**: Explain the Pledge of Allegiance and tell about the American flag - **Cyber safety**: Complete online training to learn safe internet practices

**Scout Participation** - **Scoutmaster conference**: A friendly one-on-one chat with your Scoutmaster about what you've learned

#### 4.1.4 Requirements Process: How Advancement Works

- Initially, Scouts get their rank requirements signed off by more advanced Scouts
- Scouts should bring their Scout Handbook to meetings and outings for sign-offs
- Scout's name MUST be inside and outside their book
- Scouts need a pencil or pen and small notebook for taking notes and tracking progress
- Make photocopies or take pictures of completed pages every 2-3 months in case the book is lost
- Unlike in Cub Scouts, parents may not sign off on requirements

**Important**: Your Scout Handbook is your advancement record - take good care of it and keep it with you at meetings and activities!

#### 4.1.5 Your Scout Family

During your first month, you'll meet the people who will support your Scouting journey:

**Your Patrol Leader** - An experienced Scout (usually 14-16 years old) who leads your patrol - Your primary mentor and guide during meetings and activities - Available to answer questions and help you learn Scout skills - Will work with you individually to help you complete Scout rank requirements

**Your Scoutmaster** - The adult leader who oversees the troop and your advancement - Will meet with you for your Scout rank Scoutmaster conference - Available to discuss your goals and help you succeed in Scouting - Responsible for ensuring you have a positive and safe Scouting experience

**Merit Badge Counselors** - Adult experts who will help you explore your interests through merit badges - Each counselor specializes in different subject areas - You'll work with them to complete merit badge requirements at your own pace

**Your Scout Buddy** - An experienced Scout assigned to help you during your first few months - Someone to sit with during meetings and help you feel included - Available to answer questions about troop procedures and activities

#### 4.1.6 What You'll Accomplish

By the end of your first 30 days, you'll have:

**Knowledge and Skills** - Memorized the Scout Oath, Law, Motto, and Slogan - Learned basic Scout procedures and uniform standards - Mastered your first outdoor skills (knots and knife safety) - Completed cyber safety training - Understood how advancement works in Scouting

**Achievement and Recognition** - Earned your Scout rank - your first official milestone! - Received your Scout rank patch to wear on your uniform - Completed your first Scoutmaster conference - Set goals for your continued advancement toward Tenderfoot rank

---

### 4.2 Advancement to First Class

Welcome to your journey from Scout to First Class! This is where you'll learn the essential skills that will serve you throughout your entire Scouting adventure.

The advancement path is outlined in the Scout Handbook. Scouts can work on any requirement for Scout, Tenderfoot, Second Class or First Class (ST21) or merit badges at any time. However, they can only advance a rank when ALL requirements for that rank and lower are completed.

#### 4.2.1 Your Journey: Scout to First Class

The ranks Scout → Tenderfoot → Second Class → First Class (ST21) teach you all the fundamental skills you'll need on your Scouting journey. While we encourage Scouts to work toward First Class within their first 18 months, this is a goal, not a requirement. Every Scout progresses at their own pace, and that's perfectly okay!

**Skills You'll Master**

**Outdoor Skills** - Camping and outdoor ethics (Leave No Trace principles) - Cooking skills and camp safety - First aid and emergency preparedness - Navigation using map and compass - Knots and rope work - Fire building and outdoor cooking - Weather awareness and preparation

**Physical Fitness** - Personal fitness planning and tracking - Swimming and water safety - Hiking and backpacking basics

**Leadership and Citizenship** - Leadership roles within your patrol - Community service projects - Citizenship and civic responsibility - Communication and teamwork skills

**Why First Class matters:** Scouts who earn First Class early in their Scouting journey are much more likely to stay in Scouting and eventually earn their Eagle Scout rank. These skills give you the confidence and ability to participate fully in all our outdoor adventures and leadership opportunities.

#### 4.2.2 Timeline and Requirements Overview

- **Scout**: Your introduction to Scouting (first 30 days)
- **Tenderfoot**: Basic outdoor skills and Scout knowledge (typically 2-4 months after Scout)
- **Second Class**: Intermediate camping, cooking, and outdoor skills (typically 6-8 months after Scout)
- **First Class**: Advanced outdoor skills, leadership, and citizenship (typically 12-18 months after Scout)

*Note: These are aspirational timelines. Every Scout progresses at their own pace based on their participation, effort, and opportunities to complete requirements.*

#### 4.2.3 Your Scouting Experience

#### 4.2.4 Monthly Adventures: Campouts and Hiking

Every month, our troop goes on outdoor adventures designed to help you practice and advance your skills:

**What to Expect** - Learn and practice outdoor skills in real situations - Work on advancement requirements during activities - Build friendships with your patrol members - Gain confidence in outdoor settings - Have fun while learning!

**Your Role** - Come prepared with the right gear and attitude - Participate actively in patrol activities - Help with camp setup, cooking, and cleanup - Practice leadership when given opportunities - Support your fellow Scouts

#### 4.2.5 Summer Camp: Your Big Adventure

Summer camp is a week-long experience that accelerates your advancement and skill development:

**What You'll Do** - Take merit badge classes in subjects that interest you - Participate in camp-wide activities and competitions - Practice outdoor skills in a focused environment - Meet Scouts from other troops - Experience more independence and responsibility

#### 4.2.6 Service Projects: Giving Back

Service is a core part of Scouting, and you'll have many opportunities to help others through troop projects, community service, supporting Eagle Scout projects, environmental conservation, and helping with troop activities.

#### 4.2.7 Leadership Development: Growing as a Leader

**Patrol Leadership** - Take turns serving as patrol leader or assistant patrol leader - Serve as grubmaster to plan meals and manage cooking responsibilities - Act as patrol quartermaster to organize and maintain patrol equipment - Help plan patrol activities and menus - Lead by example in your patrol - Support newer Scouts as they join

**Troop Roles** - Volunteer for troop positions as you gain experience - Help with setup and cleanup at meetings and events - Assist with teaching skills to other Scouts - Participate actively in troop meetings and activities

**Leadership Skills You'll Develop** - Communication and teamwork - Problem-solving and decision-making - Responsibility and accountability - Teaching and mentoring others (Scouting E.D.G.E. Method) - Planning and organization

#### 4.2.8 Conferences and Reviews

Scoutmaster Conferences and Boards of Review are required steps in the advancement process. Rather than repeating these at every rank, here is how they work:

**Scoutmaster Conference** - Required for **every rank**, including Scout - A one-on-one conversation between the Scout and a Scoutmaster or Assistant Scoutmaster - Not a test — this is a discussion about the Scout's experience, goals, and growth - Schedule with a Scoutmaster or Assistant Scoutmaster when you are ready to advance

**Board of Review** - Required for **all ranks beyond Scout** (Tenderfoot through Eagle) - A meeting with members of the troop committee to discuss the Scout's Scouting experience - Not a retest of requirements — requirements must already be signed off before the Board of Review - Schedule through the Advancement Coordinator or Committee Chair - **Eagle Board of Review**: Unlike other ranks, the Eagle Board of Review is conducted at the **council level**, not by the troop

For more information, see the Guide to Advancement.

A Board of Review is not a retest — it is a friendly conversation with committee members about the Scout's experience, what they've learned, and how they've grown. The only way a Scout does not pass a Board of Review is by arriving without all requirements for the rank already signed off.

#### 4.2.9 Merit Badge System

Merit badges are earned throughout your Scouting career and provide opportunities to explore interests and develop specialized skills. While not required for the First Class rank, merit badges complement your advancement journey.

**Merit Badge Process** - Talk to your Scoutmaster to get a blue card before starting any merit badge - Find counselors through our troop or the Lake Erie Council Merit Badge Counselor list - Work with merit badge counselors to complete requirements at your own pace - Complete requirements during troop meetings, camp, or individual study

**Merit Badge Opportunities** - Troop meetings and activities - Merit badge workshops at camps - Individual study with merit badge counselors - Community programs and classes - Merit badge universities - Summer camp programs

#### 4.2.10 Merit Badge Documentation

- **Electronic Records**: We use Scoutbook.com requirements tracking.
- **Merit Badge Blue Cards**: Get one from your Scoutmaster before starting a new merit badge. Have three parts when used: one for troop, one for counselor, one for Scout.
- **Merit Badge Books**: Optional but helpful resources (now available online!)

**Important for First Class Scouts**: While merit badges aren't required for Scout through First Class ranks, earning merit badges during this period helps you explore interests and prepares you for Star rank, which requires 6 merit badges.

#### 4.2.11 First Class Merit Badge Recommendations

Focus on merit badges that complement your rank advancement and can be worked on in parallel with rank requirements: - **Cooking**: Complements Second Class cooking requirements and is useful on every campout - **First Aid**: Complements First Class first aid requirements and teaches life-saving skills - **Swimming or Hiking**: Complements First Class fitness requirements and supports outdoor adventures - **Camping**: Complements camping skills learned in all ranks and enhances your outdoor experience

**Popular Choices for New Scouts** - **Communications**: Learn about different ways people communicate - **Family Life**: Explore family relationships and responsibilities - **Personal Fitness**: Develop healthy lifestyle habits - **Citizenship in the Community**: Learn about your local community and civic responsibility

More information: Scouting America Merit Badges

---

### 4.3 The Path to Eagle

The Eagle Scout rank is Scouting's highest achievement, representing years of growth, leadership, and service. After earning First Class, your Scouting journey shifts from learning basic skills to developing expertise, leadership, and making a lasting impact on your community.

#### 4.3.1 The Journey: Star to Eagle

**Star → Life → Eagle** - Emphasis shifts to leadership, service, and personal growth - Merit badge requirements become more diverse and challenging - Leadership positions require greater responsibility and longer tenure - Community service hours increase significantly

#### 4.3.2 Star Scout Requirements

**Merit Badges**: Earn 6 merit badges (4 must be from the Eagle-required list) **Time in Rank**: At least 4 months as a First Class Scout **Leadership**: Serve actively in a leadership position for 4 months **Service**: Complete 6 hours of community service **Scoutmaster Conference and Board of Review**: Required

For detailed requirements, see the Star Scout Requirements.

#### 4.3.3 Life Scout Requirements

**Merit Badges**: Earn 5 additional merit badges (3 must be from the Eagle-required list) for a total of 11 **Time in Rank**: At least 6 months as a Star Scout **Leadership**: Serve actively in a leadership position for 6 months **Service**: Complete 6 hours of community service **Scoutmaster Conference and Board of Review**: Required

For detailed requirements, see the Life Scout Requirements.

#### 4.3.4 Eagle Scout Requirements

**Time in Rank**: At least 6 months as a Life Scout

#### 4.3.5 Merit Badge Requirements

**Total**: 21 merit badges (including 13 specific Eagle-required badges and 8 elective badges of your choice)

#### 4.3.6 Eagle-Required Merit Badges

All 13 of the following merit badges are required for the Eagle Scout rank:

1. **First Aid** — Emergency response and medical skills
2. **Citizenship in the Community** — Local civic engagement
3. **Citizenship in the Nation** — National civic responsibility
4. **Citizenship in the World** — Global awareness and responsibility
5. **Communication** — Written and verbal communication skills
6. **Personal Fitness** — Physical health and wellness
7. **Emergency Preparedness** OR **Lifesaving** — Crisis response skills
8. **Environmental Science** OR **Sustainability** — Environmental stewardship
9. **Personal Management** — Financial literacy and life skills
10. **Swimming** OR **Hiking** OR **Cycling** — Physical fitness activity
11. **Camping** — Advanced outdoor skills
12. **Cooking** — Food preparation and nutrition
13. **Family Life** — Relationship and family skills

In addition to these 13 required badges, Scouts must earn **8 elective merit badges** of their choice, for a total of **21 merit badges** required for Eagle Scout.

For the full list of available merit badges, visit Scouting America Merit Badges.

#### 4.3.7 Leadership Requirement

**Position**: Serve actively in a leadership position for 6 months, including: - Senior Patrol Leader - Assistant Senior Patrol Leader - Patrol Leader - Troop Guide - Order of the Arrow Representative - Den Chief - Scribe, Librarian, Historian, Quartermaster - Junior Assistant Scoutmaster - Chaplain Aide - Instructor - Webmaster - Leave No Trace Trainer - Outdoor Ethics Guide

#### 4.3.8 Service Requirements

**Community Service**: Complete 6 hours of community service **Eagle Scout Service Project**: Plan, develop, and lead a service project that benefits a religious institution, school, or community organization (not Scouting) **Scoutmaster Conference and Board of Review**: Required — the Eagle Board of Review is conducted at the council level, not by the troop

For detailed requirements, see the Eagle Scout Requirements.

#### 4.3.9 The Eagle Scout Service Project

The Eagle project is the capstone of your Scouting experience and what often distinguishes Eagle Scouts as leaders throughout their lives.

#### 4.3.10 Project Requirements

- **Benefits**: Must help a religious institution, school, or community organization (not a Scouting unit)
- **Leadership**: You must lead the project - others can help, but you're in charge
- **Planning**: Develop detailed project proposal, timeline, and budget
- **Approval**: Get approval from your troop, beneficiary, and council before starting

- **Documentation**: Keep detailed records of planning, execution, and results

#### 4.3.11 Project Process

1. **Identify a Need**: Work with organizations to find meaningful projects
2. **Develop Your Proposal**: Create detailed plans, timelines, and resource requirements
3. **Get Approvals**: Present your proposal to troop committee, beneficiary, and council
4. **Execute Your Project**: Lead volunteers to complete the work
5. **Document Results**: Complete final reports and documentation
6. **Present to Board of Review**: Demonstrate your leadership and project impact

#### 4.3.12 Project Ideas

- Build outdoor classrooms or gardens for schools
- Create accessibility improvements for community centers
- Develop educational trails or outdoor learning spaces
- Construct storage solutions for food banks or shelters
- Organize community resource fairs or educational programs
- Design and build playground equipment or outdoor fitness areas

#### 4.3.13 Leadership Skills Developed

- **Project Management**: Planning, budgeting, scheduling, and execution
- **Team Leadership**: Motivating and directing volunteers
- **Communication**: Presenting ideas, writing proposals, and coordinating with organizations
- **Problem Solving**: Adapting to challenges and finding creative solutions
- **Service Leadership**: Understanding community needs and creating lasting impact

#### 4.3.14 Beyond Eagle: Continuing Your Journey

#### 4.3.15 Palms and Continued Recognition

- **Bronze Palm**: Earn 5 additional merit badges after Eagle
- **Gold Palm**: Earn 5 more merit badges (10 total after Eagle)
- **Silver Palm**: Earn 5 more merit badges (15 total after Eagle)
- Continue earning palms throughout your Scouting career

#### 4.3.16 Advanced Scouting Programs

- **Venturing**: High adventure and specialized interests for ages 14-21
- **Sea Scouts**: Maritime adventures and skills for ages 14-21
- **Order of the Arrow**: Scouting's national honor society

#### 4.3.17 College and Career Benefits

- **Scholarships**: Many Eagle Scout-specific scholarship opportunities
- **College Applications**: Eagle Scout recognition enhances applications
- **Career Advantages**: Leadership experience valued by employers
- **Networking**: Lifelong connections with fellow Eagle Scouts

- **Life Skills**: Project management, leadership, and service experience

#### 4.3.18 Making Eagle Achievable

#### 4.3.19 Start Early

- **Age 14**: Begin working on Eagle-required merit badges
- **Age 15-16**: Focus on leadership positions and advanced merit badges
- **Age 17**: Plan and execute Eagle project, complete final requirements
- **Age 18**: Final deadline - all requirements must be completed before 18th birthday

#### 4.3.20 Stay Organized

- **Track Progress**: Use Scoutbook to monitor advancement
- **Plan Merit Badges**: Work on Eagle-required badges early
- **Document Service**: Keep records of all service hours
- **Seek Mentorship**: Work with Eagle Scouts and adult leaders

#### 4.3.21 The Eagle Scout Legacy

Eagle Scout is more than a rank - it's a commitment to lifelong leadership and service. Eagle Scouts are found among leaders in every field: business, government, military, education, and community service.

**Remember**: Only about 4% of all Scouts earn Eagle Scout. It requires dedication, persistence, and commitment - but the rewards last a lifetime.

# 5 Adult Leaders Guide

## 5.1 Expectations of Adult Leaders

### 5.1.1 What It Means to Be an Adult Leader in Troop 500

As an adult leader in our troop, you become part of the "Association with Adults" method - one of Scouting's most powerful influences in youth development. In Troop 500, this means serving as a mentor, guide, and positive role model while supporting our Scout-led program.

Our adult leaders create safe, inclusive environments where Scouts can learn, grow, and lead. Whether you're teaching outdoor skills, mentoring a Scout through advancement, or handling troop business behind the scenes, your role is to guide rather than direct - helping Scouts develop confidence and leadership skills by allowing them to make decisions, solve problems, and learn from their experiences.

Every adult leader in our troop commits to Scouting's ideals and helps prepare our Scouts to become ethical leaders and engaged citizens in their communities.

### 5.1.2 Training Expectations

Adult leaders in Scouting America must complete required training to ensure the safety and quality of the program. Our troop is committed to having well-trained leaders who can provide the best possible experience for our Scouts.

**Safeguarding Youth Training** - Required for ALL registered adults before they can participate in any Scouting activities - Must be renewed every three years - Online training available at my.scouting.org - Covers child abuse prevention and safe Scouting practices

**Position-Specific Training** Each adult leadership position has specific training requirements: - **Scoutmaster**: Scoutmaster Position-Specific Training - **Assistant Scoutmaster**: Assistant Scoutmaster Position-Specific Training - **Committee Chair**: Committee Chair Position-Specific Training - **Committee Members**: Committee Member Position-Specific Training - **Merit Badge Counselor**: Merit Badge Counselor Training

#### 5.1.3 Responsibilities

- Uphold the Scout Oath and Scout Law in word and deed
- Maintain two-deep leadership at all activities — a minimum of two registered adults must be present
- Facilitate a youth-led program — guide rather than direct
- Ensure the physical and emotional safety of all Scouts
- Stay current on all required training and certifications
- Communicate openly with parents, Scouts, and fellow leaders
- Support troop policies, the charter organization, and council guidelines

#### 5.1.4 Behavior and Conduct

- Model the values expressed in the Scout Oath and Scout Law at all times
- Follow Scouting America's policies on youth protection, including no one-on-one contact between adults and youth
- Maintain appropriate boundaries in all interactions with Scouts
- Refrain from the use of alcohol, tobacco, or controlled substances at any Scouting activity
- Treat all members — youth and adult — with respect, dignity, and fairness
- Address conflicts constructively and through proper channels

---

### 5.2 Becoming an Adult Leader

#### 5.2.1 How to Register

To become a registered adult leader, you'll need to complete an adult leader application through BeAScout.scouting.org. This site will walk you through the registration process and help you get started with your leadership journey.

Before committing to a specific role: - Talk with current leaders about their experiences - Shadow a leader at a meeting or outing - Consider what level of involvement works for your schedule - Connect with other parents in similar roles

### 5.2.2 Becoming Position Trained




\

When you take on a formal leadership role, completing both Safeguarding Youth Training and your position-specific training makes you "position trained." Position trained leaders earn the distinctive trained patch (shown) which recognizes their commitment to providing quality Scouting experiences. This training ensures you have the knowledge and skills needed for your specific role in the troop.

**Getting Started with Training** 1. Complete Safeguarding Youth Training (your first priority) 2. Register for Position-Specific Training (check with the Training Coordinator) 3. Plan for Outdoor Training if you'll be involved in outdoor activities 4. Consider Advanced Training like Wood Badge for leadership development

For training questions or assistance with registration, contact our Training Coordinator or visit the Lake Erie Council website.

### 5.2.3 Cross-Registration with Multiple Units

Scouting America allows adults to register with more than one unit (troop, pack, crew, etc.) at the same time. This is called multiple or cross-registration.

- You may hold a different position in each unit (e.g., Committee Member in a Pack and Assistant Scoutmaster in a Troop)
- Safeguarding Youth Training carries across all registrations — you only need to complete it once
- Position-specific training is required for each distinct position you hold
- Each unit registration may require separate fees
- Coordinate with each unit's leadership to ensure clear expectations for your involvement

Cross-registration is a great option for families active in both Cub Scouts and Scouts BSA, or for adults who want to support units at different program levels.

---

## 5.3 Youth Protection Trained Adult (Not an Adult Leader)

Not every adult who participates in Scouting activities needs to hold a registered leadership position. However, **any adult** who will be present at Scouting activities — including parents attending campouts, driving Scouts, or helping at events — must complete Safeguarding Youth Training.

A Youth Protection Trained (YPT) adult: - Has completed the current Safeguarding Youth Training at my.scouting.org - May attend and assist at troop activities under the direction of registered leaders - Helps fulfill two-deep leadership and supervision requirements - Does **not** hold a registered position or have a vote on troop committee matters - Is **not** counted as a registered leader for tour plan or activity purposes

This is a great starting point for parents who want to be involved without taking on a formal role, and it is a prerequisite for any future leadership registration.

---

## 5.4 Scouter Reserve

A Scouter Reserve is a registered adult who assists as needed without holding a specific ongoing leadership position. This role is ideal for adults who want to stay connected to Scouting and be available when called upon.

- Registered adult who assists as needed
- Provides backup support for outings and activities
- Flexible involvement level based on your availability
- Good stepping stone to more involved leadership roles
- Requires Safeguarding Youth Training

---

## 5.5 Merit Badge Counselor

A merit badge counselor is a registered adult with knowledge and enthusiasm about a career, hobby, or other subject who is willing to share that knowledge and enthusiasm with Scouts. As a merit badge counselor, you can:

- Share your expertise by counseling Scouts in merit badges related to your profession or hobbies
- Work with individual Scouts or small groups on a flexible schedule
- Contribute meaningfully without ongoing meeting attendance requirements
- Requires Safeguarding Youth Training and Merit Badge Counselor position-specific training

Merit badge counselors are registered at the council level, which means you may work with Scouts from any unit — not just Troop 500.

More information: Merit Badge Counselor Guide Find merit badge opportunities: Lake Erie Council Merit Badge Counselor List

---

## 5.6 Committee Member

The Troop Committee handles the business side of Scouting, allowing our Scoutmasters to focus on the youth program. Committee members typically commit to:

- Attend monthly committee meetings (usually 1-2 hours, held on a weeknight)
- Support one or more specialized areas based on your interests and skills
- Help with planning and coordination behind the scenes
- Assist with troop business and administrative functions

**Committee Specialties Include:**

- **Secretary**: Keep meeting minutes and maintain troop records
- **Treasurer**: Manage troop finances and track Scout accounts
- **Outdoor Activities Coordinator**: Plan and coordinate troop outings and special events
- **Advancement Coordinator**: Track Scout progress and coordinate boards of review
- **Chaplain**: Provides spiritual tone for troop meetings and activities
- **Training Coordinator**: Help adults complete required training
- **Equipment Coordinator**: Maintain and organize troop gear

- **Membership Coordinator**: Develop a plan for year-round membership flow into the troop
- **Others as needed**: Troops are encouraged to engage all parents in a role that suits their skills and interests

**Training Required:** Safeguarding Youth Training + Committee Member (or Committee Chair) Position-Specific Training

---

## 5.7 Assistant Scoutmaster

Assistant Scoutmasters work on the front lines of the youth program, directly supporting Scouts and the Scoutmaster in delivering a quality outdoor experience.

- Work directly with youth leaders and patrols
- Attend regular troop meetings and outings
- Mentor youth in leadership development and outdoor skills
- Serve as a role model and resource for Scouts in the field

**Training Required:** - Safeguarding Youth Training - Assistant Scoutmaster Position-Specific Training - Introduction to Outdoor Leader Skills (IOLS) — a hands-on course providing the practical outdoor skills needed to lead Scouts in the out-of-doors. Upon completion, leaders should feel comfortable teaching Scouts the basic skills required to obtain the First Class rank. (IOLS Information) - Hazardous Weather Training

---

## 5.8 Scoutmaster

The Scoutmaster is the primary adult leader responsible for the overall quality of the troop's youth program. This role requires a significant commitment of time, energy, and heart.

- Primary youth program leader for the troop
- Responsible for overall program quality and youth development
- Mentors and guides all youth leaders in the troop
- Works closely with the Troop Committee, Assistant Scoutmasters, and parents
- Represents the troop to the charter organization and council

**Training Required:** - Safeguarding Youth Training - Scoutmaster Position-Specific Training - Introduction to Outdoor Leader Skills (IOLS) - Hazardous Weather Training

---

## 5.9 Charter Organization Representative

The Charter Organization Representative (COR) is the direct link between Troop 500 and our charter organization, Advent Lutheran Church. The COR serves on both the troop committee and the council level.

- Serves as the liaison between the charter organization and the troop
- Approves adult leader applications on behalf of the charter organization
- Has a vote on troop committee decisions and at the council level
- Ensures the troop's program aligns with the charter organization's values and mission
- Attends troop committee meetings and council meetings as the charter organization's representative

**Training Required:** Safeguarding Youth Training + Charter Organization Representative Position-Specific Training

---

## 5.10 Additional Training Opportunities




\

Beyond required training, Scouting offers many opportunities for continued growth and development.

### 5.10.1 Outdoor Training

- Wilderness First Aid — Recommended for outdoor activity leaders
- Leave No Trace Trainer — Environmental stewardship training

### 5.10.2 Leadership Development

- Wood Badge — Advanced leadership training for new and experienced leaders (Wood Badge Information)
- University of Scouting — Council-sponsored training events
- Scouting EDGE — The EDGE method is practiced throughout Scouting and is Scouting's most effective training tool. Whether training Scout leaders in their position or teaching new outdoor skills to youth or new adult leaders, this training will give you the tools to keep your audience engaged while helping your instruction stick in their minds.

### 5.10.3 Event and Safety-Specific Training

- Climb On Safely — For climbing and rappelling activities
- Safety Afloat — For aquatic activities
- Trek Safely — For hiking and backpacking
- Shooting Sports Director Training — For firearms and archery programs

### 5.10.4 Continual Training

**Roundtable** Once a month Scouting volunteers in a local community come together to provide information about local Scouting events, activities, and programs. Roundtables play a significant role in providing continuous supplemental training for unit leaders. This monthly event provides program topic guidance and structure suggestions for unit leaders. A fun environment creates excitement around the coming month of activities and program for unit leaders to carry back for implementation in their units. As an alternative or in addition to in-person Roundtables you can participate in virtual Roundtables.

**University of Scouting / Pow Wow** These opportunities may be available through your local council. Typically these are a series of courses that take place in one day and often provide the opportunity to take several sessions on various topics that help you provide a great program.

**Remember**: Every youth deserves a trained leader. Your commitment to training ensures we provide the highest quality Scouting program possible, and there's a place for every parent to contribute meaningfully to their Scout's experience.

# 6 Outdoor Program & High Adventure

The outdoor program is the heart of Troop 500G. Everything we do — from monthly campouts to weeklong high adventure treks — is designed to build skills, confidence, and self-reliance in our Scouts. Our program follows a deliberate progression: master the fundamentals close to home, then take those skills into bigger, bolder adventures.

---

## 6.1 Building the Foundation: Monthly Outdoor Program

We camp monthly, year-round, in all weather conditions. These regular outings are where Scouts develop the core skills that make high adventure possible.

### 6.1.1 What Our Monthly Program Looks Like

- **Car camping** at established campgrounds — great for newer Scouts learning the basics
- **Day hikes and trail skills** — building endurance, navigation, and awareness
- **Winter camping** — cold-weather skills including layering, cold-weather cooking, and shelter management
- **Backpacking trips** — carrying everything you need and working as a team on the trail
- **Canoe and kayak outings** — water skills and paddle safety (when available)

### 6.1.2 Skills That Build Toward Adventure

Every monthly outing reinforces skills Scouts will need for high adventure:

| Skill Area | Monthly Program | High Adventure Application |
|---|---|---|
| Navigation | Map & compass practice on local trails | Backcountry route-finding at Philmont |
| Cooking | Grubmaster rotations at campouts | Trail meal planning on multi-day treks |
| Physical fitness | Hikes with increasing distance and elevation | 50+ mile treks at altitude |
| Gear management | Packing for weekend trips | Ultralight backpacking for extended expeditions |
| Teamwork | Patrol cooking and camp setup | Crew-based decision-making in remote settings |
| Weather readiness | Four-season camping in Northeast Ohio | Variable conditions at any high adventure base |

#### 6.1.3 Essential Gear

Every Scout should have their own basic camping equipment. See our Ten Essentials guide and Tent Camping List for detailed packing information.

#### 6.1.4 Grubmaster Program

Our grubmaster system teaches Scouts meal planning, budgeting, and cooking skills. Each Scout takes turns being responsible for planning and preparing meals for the patrol during camping trips. This hands-on responsibility is one of the best ways to prepare for high adventure, where every crew member shares the load.

Resources: - Grubmaster 101 - Basic meal planning - Grubmaster 201 - Advanced cooking techniques

---

### 6.2 The Path to High Adventure

High adventure is where all the monthly training pays off. These are extended, challenging expeditions at Scouting America's premier wilderness bases — experiences that Scouts remember for the rest of their lives.

#### 6.2.1 Scouting America High Adventure Bases

**Philmont Scout Ranch** — Cimarron, New Mexico - 10-12 day backcountry treks through the Rocky Mountains - 50-100+ miles of hiking at elevations above 9,000 feet - Activities include rock climbing, burro packing, black powder shooting, and conservation projects - Crews of 8-12 Scouts and advisors navigate the backcountry together

**Northern Tier Canoe Base** — Ely, Minnesota / Bissett, Manitoba / Atikokan, Ontario - 6-10 day wilderness canoe expeditions through the Boundary Waters and Quetico - Paddling, portaging, and fishing in pristine northern lakes - Scouts learn canoe skills, wilderness navigation, and cold-water safety

**Florida Sea Base** — Islamorada, Florida - Sailing, snorkeling, and scuba adventures in the Florida Keys - Programs include live-aboard sailing, coral reef exploration, and island hopping - Marine ecology and ocean conservation education

**Summit Bechtel Reserve** — Glen Jean, West Virginia - Home of the National Scout Jamboree - Mountain biking, zip lining, whitewater rafting, rock climbing, and skateboarding - Adventure programs and STEM activities year-round

#### 6.2.2 Who Can Participate

- **Age**: Scouts must be at least 14 years old (or 13 and have completed 8th grade, depending on the base)
- **Rank**: First Class rank is strongly recommended before attending any high adventure program
- **Fitness**: Scouts must meet physical fitness requirements specific to each base (some require a physician-certified health form with BMI or fitness benchmarks)
- **Skills**: Scouts should be comfortable with multi-day camping, cooking on the trail, navigation, and personal gear management

#### 6.2.3 How Our Outdoor Program Prepares You

The progression is intentional:

1. **New Scout (Year 1)** — Learn the basics at monthly campouts: fire building, cooking, knots, first aid, tent setup, and Leave No Trace
2. **Developing Scout (Year 2)** — Take on more responsibility: serve as grubmaster, navigate with map and compass, backpack with a full pack, camp in winter conditions
3. **Experienced Scout (Year 3+)** — Lead others and push your limits: mentor younger Scouts on outings, tackle longer hikes, and begin preparing for a high adventure trek
4. **High Adventure Ready** — Apply everything you've learned in a challenging wilderness setting with your crew

#### 6.2.4 Planning and Preparation

High adventure trips require significant planning, typically starting 12-18 months in advance:

- **Registration**: Most bases accept reservations well in advance and popular dates fill quickly
- **Physical training**: Scouts should follow a training plan that builds endurance (hiking with a loaded pack, cardio, and strength training)
- **Shakedown trips**: The troop organizes practice backpacking trips to test gear, fitness, and crew dynamics before departure
- **Fundraising**: High adventure trips involve travel and base fees — Scouts are encouraged to participate in troop fundraising and can pursue individual fundraising with Scoutmaster approval
- **Gear check**: Crews review personal and group gear to minimize weight and ensure readiness

---

### 6.3 Leave No Trace

All outdoor activities — from a local campout to a high adventure trek — follow the seven Leave No Trace principles:

1. **Plan ahead and prepare**
2. **Travel and camp on durable surfaces**
3. **Dispose of waste properly**
4. **Leave what you find**
5. **Minimize campfire impacts**
6. **Respect wildlife**
7. **Be considerate of other visitors**

Leave No Trace isn't just a set of rules — it's a mindset. Scouts who practice these principles on every outing develop the outdoor ethics expected at every high adventure base.

---

### 6.4 Summer Camp

Summer camp is a weeklong experience that bridges the gap between monthly outings and high adventure. Scouts earn merit badges, practice outdoor skills in a focused environment, and experience more independence

— all in a supported camp setting. For many Scouts, summer camp is the first step toward wanting more adventure.

---

### 6.5 Getting Involved

Talk to the Scoutmaster or Outdoor Program Coordinator about: - Upcoming campouts and how to sign up - What gear you need to get started - Training opportunities for high adventure preparation - Which high adventure base might be right for you

---

## 7 Appendix

### 7.1 Appendix A: Joining Conference

**Download as PDF:** Joining Conference Template (PDF)

#### 7.1.1 Overview

*Every Scout who joins Troop 500G brings their own unique strengths, interests, and needs — and this conference is our chance to learn about yours. By taking a little time to talk before your Scout's first campout, we can make sure our leaders are prepared to support them from day one. This form is a guide for that conversation, not an evaluation — there are no wrong answers, and you are always welcome to leave any question blank. Everything shared here stays confidential within our leadership team and is used only to help your Scout thrive.*

---

**7.1.1.1 A Note About Scout Leadership** Troop 500G leaders are volunteers — mostly parents who care deeply about Scouts and want to help. We attend a lot of training, but we also have full-time jobs and busy lives. Sometimes we miss details or make mistakes, but our goal is always to support your Scout and help them succeed. Just as Scouts "Do their best," we do too. If you ever have concerns or questions, please talk to us. We'll figure it out together!

---

**7.1.1.2 A Conversation Guide** The Lake Erie Council Accessibility and Inclusion Committee encourages Units to hold joining conferences with every incoming Scout. These meetings are between leaders (often Scoutmasters, Assistant Scoutmasters, and New Member Coordinators), parents, and Scouts. Joining meetings encourage inclusive, strengths-based conversations to better understand and support each Scout's unique needs. The conference should take place within the first month after a Scout joins, and is designed to build partnerships with families rather than evaluate suitability.

**7.1.1.3 Inclusive** Joining conferences are held for every Scout, recognizing that all Scouts have unique needs and strengths. Some may require additional support, but every Scout benefits from understanding and partnership.

**7.1.1.4 Confidentiality & Privacy** The goal of joining conferences is to provide leaders enough information to support Scouts during camping and troop activities. While confidentiality is important, we ask that parents and guardians share enough information with our trained leaders to help their Scout succeed. Required Annual Health and Medical Forms store private medical information and are not authorized for digital storage. All joining conference information is stored in Troop 500G Google Drive, with access limited to adult troop leaders who need it to provide support to your Scout. If you have privacy concerns, please let us know. You may leave any fields blank if you prefer not to share certain information. All details discussed are kept confidential unless explicit permission is given to share with other leaders.

**7.1.1.5 You're part of the team** Leaders, parents, and Scouts work together as a team, and the goal is a supportive partnership where every Scout can thrive. Open communication is essential — if something is worrying you, please say so. If something is unclear, just ask. We would rather hear about a concern early than have a Scout struggle in silence.

**7.1.1.6 Strengths-Based** Every Scout brings their own unique strengths, talents, and interests. The joining conference focuses on identifying and building upon these strengths, helping Scouts feel confident and valued in the troop. That said, building on strengths is most effective when leaders also understand where a Scout might struggle — knowing potential challenges helps us provide the right support before small difficulties become bigger ones.

**7.1.1.7 No Diagnosis Required** The conversation is about what helps the Scout succeed — not about medical diagnoses or labels. Families are encouraged to share strategies, preferences, and needs, regardless of whether there is a formal diagnosis.

**7.1.1.8 Conducted Post-Joining** The joining conference is held after the Scout has joined the troop. It is not an evaluation or selection process, but a way to welcome the Scout and ensure they have the support they need from the start.

**7.1.1.9 An Ongoing Conversation** The joining conference is just the beginning of a supportive relationship. Scouts, parents, and leaders all grow and change, and so do their needs. Any leader, Scout, or parent may request another conference at any time to revisit goals, address new challenges, or update support strategies. We especially encourage a follow-up conference with leaders and families before Scouts attend summer camp, to ensure everyone is prepared and supported for new experiences.

### 7.1.2 Pre-Meeting Checklist

*This section is to be completed by troop leadership prior to the Joining Conference.*

- ☐ Scout has joined the Troop *(beascout.scouting.org)*
- ☐ Private, confidential meeting space arranged *(out of earshot of others)*
- ☐ At least one disability-awareness trained leader present if possible
- ☐ Family understands this is about understanding their Scout, not evaluation
- ☐ Troop 500G Handbook *(Printed Hardcopy)*
- ☐ Below form has been sent to family for review

#### 7.1.3 Scout Contact Information

Scout Name: _____ Age: _____

Gender: _____ Preferred Pronouns:_____

Birthday: _____ Grade: _____

School: _____

Phone: _____ Scout's Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Siblings: _____

Sibling Scouting involvement: _____

##### 7.1.3.1 Emergency Contact

Who should we contact if parent(s)/guardian(s) are unavailable?

Name: _____ Relationship: _____

Phone: _____

##### 7.1.3.2 Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record A & B *(C before summer camp)*
- ☐ IEP / 504 *(As Needed)*
- ☐ Social Media Waiver
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar

#### 7.1.4 Parent / Guardian 1 Contact Information

Name: _____

Relationship to Scout: _____

Phone: _____ Secondary Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Previous Scouting Experience: _____

##### 7.1.4.1 Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Reviewed Safe Scouting Pamphlet with Scout
- ☐ Youth Protection Training Complete
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar
- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record *As Needed*

##### 7.1.4.2 How would you like to help?

- ☐ I would like to focus on my Scout for now!
- ☐ I can help with small side-tasks and events!
- ☐ Scouter Reserve, able to attend some campouts (Registration Required)
- ☐ Committee member (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Assistant Scoutmaster, Planning Campouts/Events (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Merit badge counselor (Registration / Training Required)

**7.1.4.3 Skills, Interests or Resources** What do you know, or are good at that you want to share?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

#### 7.1.5 Parent / Guardian 2 Contact Information

Name: _____

Relationship to Scout: _____

Phone: _____ Secondary Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Previous Scouting Experience: _____

##### 7.1.5.1 Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Reviewed Safe Scouting Pamphlet with Scout
- ☐ Youth Protection Training Complete
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar
- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record *As Needed*

##### 7.1.5.2 How would you like to help?

- ☐ I would like to focus on my Scout for now!
- ☐ I can help with small side-tasks and events!
- ☐ Scouter Reserve, able to attend some campouts (Registration Required)
- ☐ Committee member (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Assistant Scoutmaster, Planning Campouts/Events (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Merit badge counselor (Registration / Training Required)

**7.1.5.3 Skills, Interests or Resources** What do you know, or are good at that you want to share?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

#### 7.1.6 About Your Scout

**7.1.6.1 Scouting Experience** Previous Scouting Experience: _____

Why did your Scout want to join our troop? _____

_____

Does your Scout like to camp? _____

Do you consider your Scout a swimmer? _____

What is your Scout's goal in Scouting? _____

_____

**7.1.6.2 Strengths & Interests** What are your Scout's unique strengths? _____

_____

What does your Scout enjoy most? What are they passionate about? _____

_____

What makes them feel successful and confident? _____

_____

Hobbies: _____

_____

**7.1.6.3 Allergies / Dietary Considerations** Allergies: _____

_____

Dietary restrictions: _____

_____

Is your Scout a picky eater? What foods will they eat, and what do they refuse or strongly dislike?

_____

_____

**7.1.6.4 Medical, Physical, & Sensory Considerations** Any physical limitations or accommodations needed? _____

_____

Any Medical conditions we should be aware of? (Details in AHMR) _____

_____

Can your Scout take pills? _____

Is your Scout prepared for her period? _____

Bedtime and sleep routines *(important for overnight and camping trips)*:

- Regular bedtime: _____
- Bedtime routine or needs: _____
- Sleep concerns *(sleepwalking, nightmares, sleep aids, etc.)*: _____

Sensory sensitivities? (loud noises, bright lights, textures, crowds, etc.) _____

_____

What happens if your Scout misses meds? _____

_____

**7.1.6.5 Learning & Communication Style** How does your Scout learn best? (visual, hands-on, verbal instructions, etc.) _____

_____

Are there any concerns with reading, writing, or comprehension? _____

_____

What strategies work well at home or school to help them learn? _____

_____

**7.1.6.6 Social & Emotional Needs** How does your Scout handle new situations or changes to routine?

_____

_____

What helps them be successful in small or large group settings? _____

_____

Does anything trigger anxiety, overwhelm, or emotional struggles? _____

_____

What are the warning signs when they're becoming overwhelmed? _____

_____

What strategies help when they're struggling? How can we help them succeed? _____

_____

**7.1.6.7 Previous Experiences & Concerns** What accommodations or adaptations are made at home and school? _____

_____

What concerns do you have about your Scout's participation in Scouting? _____

_____

Any previous challenges with group activities or programs? _____

_____

**7.1.6.8 Family Considerations** *This information is kept strictly confidential and used only to ensure your Scout's safety and success.*

Any family needs, situations, or custody arrangements we should be aware of?

*(e.g., who may pick up the Scout, communication preferences between households, court orders, etc.)*

_____

_____

_____

_____

Who is authorized to pick up the Scout? _____

Anyone who is NOT authorized to pick up the Scout? _____

#### 7.1.7 Support Strategies & Action Planning

**7.1.7.1 What Works for Your Scout?** Strategies that help them succeed: _____

_____

What should we make sure to do for your Scout? _____

_____

What should we avoid doing or be careful about? _____

_____

When they're struggling, how do you help them? How can we help? _____

_____

### 7.1.8 What else should we know?

What else should we know or talk about? _____

#### 7.1.9 Conference Summary

To be filled out by Troop Leadership during the Joining Conference.

##### 7.1.9.1 Main Concerns

- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____

Scout's key strengths to build upon: _____

_____

Primary support strategies identified: _____

_____

Accommodations/adaptations to implement: _____

_____

**Download this template as PDF:** Joining Conference Template (PDF)

---

### 7.2 Appendix B: Scout Camps We Frequent

**Download as PDF:** Scout Camps We Frequent (PDF)

Our troop has experience with many excellent Scout camps throughout Ohio and the surrounding region. These camps offer diverse programs, beautiful settings, and memorable experiences for our Scouts.

**Recent Summer Camps:** - **2025**: Beaumont Scout Reservation, Seven Ranges Scout Reservation - **2026**: Pioneer Scout Reservation *(scheduled)*

**Special Events:** - **2026**: National Jamboree at Summit Bechtel Reserve *(contingent participating)*

#### 7.2.1 Lake Erie Council Camps

**7.2.1.1 Beaumont Scout Reservation** Lake Erie Council's Scout reservation offering unique programs and outdoor experiences, providing Scouts with opportunities to develop new skills and create lasting memories.

**7.2.1.2 Firelands Scout Reservation** Lake Erie Council Scout reservation featuring diverse programming options, outdoor adventure activities, and excellent facilities for summer camp and weekend events.

#### 7.2.2 Great Trail Council Camps

**7.2.2.1 Manatoc Scout Reservation** Great Trail Council's premier Scout reservation featuring aquatic programs, traditional Scout camping, and a wide variety of merit badge opportunities in a scenic lakeside location.

**7.2.2.2 Camp Stambaugh** A premier Scout camp located in Mineral Ridge, Ohio, within the Manatoc Scout Reservation under Great Trail Council. Camp Stambaugh offers comprehensive summer camp programs, weekend camping, and outdoor adventure activities in a beautiful wooded setting.

**7.2.2.3 Camp Butler** Located within the Manatoc Scout Reservation, Camp Butler offers summer programs and outdoor adventures with a focus on traditional Scouting skills and leadership development.

### 7.2.3 Buckeye Council Camps

**7.2.3.1 Seven Ranges Scout Reservation** Buckeye Council's Scout reservation offering comprehensive summer camp programs and outdoor adventure activities. Our troop participated in summer camp here in 2025, experiencing their excellent facilities and programming.

### 7.2.4 Erie Shores Council Camps

**7.2.4.1 Pioneer Scout Reservation** Erie Shores Council's Pioneer Scout Reservation includes Camp Frontier and offers excellent summer camp programs with a focus on outdoor skills, leadership development, and traditional Scouting experiences.

### 7.2.5 Independent and Regional Camps

**7.2.5.1 Camp Tuscazoar** Founded more than a century ago, Camp Tuscazoar is now operated by the Camp Tuscazoar Foundation as an Ohio non-profit corporation. This historic camp continues to serve Scouts and youth organizations while also welcoming weekend campers, hikers, mountain bikers, and horse riders throughout the year.

**7.2.5.2 Laurel Highlands High Adventure** A high adventure destination we're interested in visiting in the future. Laurel Highlands offers exciting outdoor adventure programs and activities that provide Scouts with opportunities to challenge themselves and develop confidence in wilderness settings.

### 7.2.6 Local Outdoor Adventure Partners

**7.2.6.1 Camp Hi Adventure** A privately-owned outdoor adventure facility on the Cuyahoga River, operated by the Hazlett family since 1928. Our troop has historically participated in family canoe and kayak events following the annual Twins Day Festival. With over 250 canoes, kayaks, and paddle boards, Camp Hi provides "Adventure in Your Own Backyard" experiences that promote the restorative benefits of river recreation.

### 7.2.7 National High Adventure Bases

For comprehensive information about all National High Adventure Bases, visit Scouting America's High Adventure page.

**7.2.7.1 Philmont Scout Ranch** Our Scouts and Scouters have participated in treks at Philmont Scout Ranch, Scouting America's premier high adventure base in New Mexico. This 140,000-acre wilderness ranch offers life-changing backpacking experiences that challenge Scouts physically, mentally, and spiritually while building leadership skills and lifelong memories.

**7.2.7.2 Sea Base** Scouting America's aquatic high adventure base in the Florida Keys offers unique maritime adventures including sailing, snorkeling, scuba diving, and marine conservation programs in some of the most beautiful waters in the world.

**7.2.7.3 Northern Tier** Located in Minnesota's Boundary Waters Canoe Area Wilderness, Northern Tier provides canoe and backpacking adventures in pristine wilderness settings, offering Scouts the opportunity to experience untouched nature and develop self-reliance skills.

#### 7.2.8 Camp Selection Process

Our troop chooses different camps each summer based on several factors: - **Scout Preferences**: We let our Scouts' interests drive our camp selection - **Program Offerings**: Different camps excel in different areas (aquatics, high adventure, traditional skills, etc.) - **New Experiences**: We like to expose our Scouts to different camp environments and programs - **Quality and Safety**: All selected camps maintain high standards for safety and program quality

#### 7.2.9 Planning Your Camp Experience

**Before Camp:** - Visit camp websites to learn about their programs and facilities - Check what merit badges and activities will be available - Prepare by reviewing Scout skills and requirements

**During Camp:** - Participate fully in all activities and programs - Work on advancement opportunities - Build friendships with Scouts from other troops - Embrace new challenges and experiences

**After Camp:** - Share your experiences with the troop - Complete any follow-up requirements for merit badges - Apply skills learned at camp to future troop activities

*For information about this year's summer camp destination and upcoming camp opportunities, contact the troop leadership or check our current calendar.*

---

### 7.3 Appendix C: Useful Links

**Download as PDF:** Useful Links (PDF)

Here are some valuable online resources to support your Scouting journey and help you make the most of your experience in Troop 500G.

#### 7.3.1 Official Scouting America Resources

**7.3.1.1 Scouting.org** The official Scouting America website with comprehensive information about programs, policies, resources, and news. Essential for staying current with Scouting updates and accessing official materials.

**7.3.1.2 Be a Scout** The official resource for new families and potential Scouts. Learn about Scouting programs, find local units, and discover what makes Scouting special.

**7.3.1.3 Scouts BSA Resources** Official resources specifically for Scouts BSA participants, including advancement information, activity guides, forms, and program materials.

### 7.3.2 Scout Life and Inspiration

**7.3.2.1 Scout Life Magazine** The official magazine of Scouting America featuring outdoor adventure stories, Scouting news, advancement tips, games, and inspiring stories from Scouts across the country.

**7.3.2.2 Scouting America YouTube Channel** Official video content including outdoor skills tutorials, advancement guidance, inspiring Scout stories, and program information to enhance your Scouting experience.

**7.3.2.3 TroopLeader Online** Comprehensive digital resource hub for Scouts, families, and Scouters featuring advancement tracking, leadership position guides, troop structure information, and practical resources for all aspects of the Scouting program.

### 7.3.3 Local Resources

**7.3.3.1 Lake Erie Council** Our local Scout council serving Northeast Ohio. Find council-wide events, training schedules, camp information, forms, and local Scouting news. Essential for staying connected with the broader Scouting community in our region.

**7.3.3.2 Scout Shop - Lake Erie Council** Official Scout Shop at Lake Erie Council Headquarters (2241 Woodland Ave, Cleveland, Ohio) for purchasing uniforms, badges, handbooks, and other Scouting gear.

**7.3.3.3 Scout Shop - Great Trail Council** Alternative Scout Shop serving Northeast Ohio, providing uniforms, patches, handbooks, camping gear, and other official Scouting merchandise.

### 7.3.4 Getting the Most from These Resources

**For New Scouts:** - Start with Be a Scout to understand the basics - Explore Scout Life Magazine for fun activities and inspiration - Watch YouTube videos to see Scouting skills in action

**For Advancing Scouts:** - Use Scouts BSA Resources for advancement requirements - Explore TroopLeader Online for leadership position guides and troop structure - Check Scouting.org for the latest program updates - Follow Scout Life for outdoor adventure ideas and leadership tips

**For Parents:** - Visit Scouting.org for parent resources and volunteer opportunities - Check Lake Erie Council for training schedules and local events - Explore Be a Scout to understand the full Scouting program - Use these resources to support your Scout's advancement journey

### 7.3.5 Stay Connected

These links are great starting points, but remember that your local Troop 500G community is your primary resource. Don't hesitate to ask your patrol leaders, adult leaders, or fellow Scouts for guidance and support!

*For the most current links and additional resources, visit our troop website at troop500.org*

---

## 7.4 Appendix D: Troop Contact Information

**Download as PDF:** Troop Contact Information (PDF)

### 7.4.1 Chartered Organization




\

#### 7.4.1.1 Chartered Organization Representative: Anthony Binkowsky

Phone: [Contact through charter organization]
Email: [Contact through charter organization]

### 7.4.2 Scoutmasters




\

#### 7.4.2.1 Scoutmaster: Jenni Ferro

Phone: 917-658-3022
Email: jcelia@hotmail.com




\

#### 7.4.2.2 Assistant Scoutmaster: Ryan May

Phone: 216-385-5341
Email: spockmay@gmail.com




\

#### 7.4.2.3 Assistant Scoutmaster: Shari Armstrong

Phone: 216-650-3059
Email: shari.l.armstrong@gmail.com




\

#### 7.4.2.4 Assistant Scoutmaster: Arunkumar Srinivasan

Phone: 614-216-2519
Email: mrarunks@yahoo.com

### 7.4.3 Troop Committee




\

**7.4.3.1 Committee Chair: Heather Gansler** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: heatherlgee@gmail.com

**7.4.3.2 Scribe / Records Coordinator: Vickie Schroeder** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]

**7.4.3.3 Treasurer: Renee Kirbawy** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]

**7.4.3.4 New Member Coordinator: Nick Kelley** Phone: 330-979-8897
Email: Nick.Kelley@att.net

**7.4.3.5 Advancement Coordinator: Doug Gansler** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: doug.gansler@gmail.com




\

**7.4.3.6 Equipment Coordinator: Corey Murphy** Phone: 814-573-2304
Email: c.murphy360@gmail.com

**7.4.3.7 Special Events / Service Project Coordinator: Vacant** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]

**7.4.3.8 Fundraising Coordinator: Vacant** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]

**7.4.3.9 Recruitment Coordinator: Vacant** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]

**7.4.3.10 New Family Guide: Vacant** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]




\

**7.4.3.11 Webmaster: Ryan May** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]

**7.4.3.12 Outdoor Chair: Arunkumar Srinivasan** Phone: 614-216-2519
Email: mrarunks@yahoo.com

**7.4.3.13 Mid-Adventure Coordinator: Arunkumar Srinivasan, Jim Stoddard-Dare** Phone: [Contact through Outdoor Chair]
Email: thedarefamily2003@gmail.com

**7.4.3.14 High Adventure Coordinator: Arunkumar Srinivasan, Jim Stoddard-Dare** Phone: [Contact through Outdoor Chair]
Email: thedarefamily2003@gmail.com

**7.4.3.15 Eagle Scout Coordinator: Steve Herman, Nirav Vora** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]







**7.4.3.16 Troop Librarian and Historian: Vacant** Phone: [To be updated]
Email: [To be updated]

**7.4.3.17 General Contact** For questions about the troop or this handbook: - Attend any weekly meeting (Monday evenings at Advent Lutheran Church) - Contact the Scoutmaster or New Member Coordinator - Visit our website at troop500.org

**7.4.3.18 Communication GroupMe Groups** We communicate via GroupMe with separate groups for adults and Scouts. Contact the Scoutmaster or committee members to be added to the appropriate groups. All Scout communication groups are monitored by two-deep adult leadership to ensure safety.

**Two-Deep Communication Policy** Whenever there is any online, text, virtual, or phone communication between a Scout and an adult, there must always be two adults participating in the communication, maintaining our two-deep leadership standard.

---

*Ready to start your Scouting adventure? Let's explore what Troop 500G has to offer!*

**Download Contact Directory as PDF:** Contact Directory (PDF)